ALIA BUCKNER

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I've spent 8 years in product: 4 at Microsoft learning the craft, then 4 at a mission-driven Series B startup in Kenya, where I built products from 0→1 and my role grew to include strategy, operations, and commercial results. I went from Senior PM to the leadership team in under 3 years and led an overhaul of our product and go-to-market that more than tripled retention. Even as VP, I stayed hands-on: visiting customers on their farms in rural Kenya, spending hours in SQL looking for patterns, and prototyping and building new features myself. I love moving between the details and the big picture, and using each to sharpen the other.

Experience

Apollo Agriculture

Aug 2022 – Aug 2026

Series B agri-fintech providing credit, farm inputs, and advice to smallholder farmers in Kenya and Zambia (430k+ served, $90M+ lent).

Director of Product → VP of Product — Nairobi, Kenya · Jul 2024 – Aug 2026

Member of the 6-person leadership team. Owned product strategy across our core businesses and co-owned the technology platform behind them with the CTO. Led the 5-person product team running those businesses, with accountability for their commercial results.

- Led the design and build of a new technology platform to power Apollo's 2026 expansion from maize into other crops, the company's top strategic priority. Cut the time to launch a new product from ~4 weeks of engineering work to minutes with no engineers needed, to learn and iterate faster. Then led the teams that used it to launch 3 new product lines within 6 months.
- Ran field research on why farmers weren't renewing and turned it into the thesis behind Apollo's 2024 company strategy. Designed and built the program at the heart of that strategy, turning one-off sales into year-round customer relationships, with a dedicated field officer for each farmer and monthly visits, guided by a reworked app.
- Set company records for retention (~50% above previous best) and repayment (91%) in the program's first full season, after proving it in a controlled pilot with ~10,000 farmers (a 20% lift in retention) and scaling it company-wide to replace ~16,000 commission-only agents.

Senior Product Manager — Amsterdam, NL · Aug 2022 – Jul 2024

- Rebuilt Apollo's loan-only purchase flow to accept cash, adding 30k+ cash customers in its first season. Interviewed ~50 farmers to rethink how we presented prices, and prototyped and shipped a pay-more-upfront option that 35% of customers chose.
- Launched Apollo's first direct-to-farmer channel, a web store designed for rural farmers new to smartphones. Ran usability tests with 50+ of those farmers and set up the team's first funnel analytics and A/B testing. Spotted shopkeepers repurposing the store to sell our inputs for cash, uncovering demand that later led to our investment in a cash channel.
- Redesigned customer onboarding after shadowing agents in the field, making credit decisions instant for every farmer and cutting sign-up time by 30%. Also built a self-serve catalog tool so the commercial team could target products to each farmer segment.

Microsoft

Redmond, WA · Sep 2018 – Jul 2022

Product Manager → Product Manager II → Senior Product Manager

- Built the rules engine at the core of Microsoft's effort to turn its internal fraud-protection system into a SaaS product for merchants. Drove its roadmap for 2 years, shaping it into the centerpiece of customer demos and sales conversations.
- Recovered a deteriorating relationship with Worldline, our largest prospective customer, as the sole PM on the account: made 3 trips to Amsterdam in 3 months, turned their concerns into a 9-month roadmap, and delivered it in full, clearing the way for Worldline to offer our product to hundreds of its merchants.
- Defined and drove an ML feature for Azure's on-call engineers, grouping related alerts across services into single incidents and cutting incident volume 60%+ in private preview. Co-inventor on the resulting US patent.

Facebook · Software Engineering Intern — Menlo Park, CA · Summer 2016

- Built profile videos for Facebook's desktop site, porting the feature's mobile infrastructure to web in React and Hack.

Education

Pomona College · BA, Computer Science — Claremont, CA · 2018